

Solent Tales Set

A Tragic Accident

I first came across this tale, and the tale that it alludes to, in the Ferryman pub in Lymington, where we often pass the time if we've time to wait on a boat.

It dates back to a particular September, in the early 1890s, and a local gamekeeper, named Henry Card, a father of nine young children, who was wandering along the river path on the Walhampton side, towards the Waggon and Horses, as the Ferryman pub was called then, with his dog at his side.

He stopped to chat to an old friend who was working in one of the fields, and as he did so, snapped open his gun to take out the cartridges.

Distracted by a train on the other side of the river there, Henry remarked on how busy it was. Then the two men separated, and Henry went for his pint.

Inside the pub the bar chat was all about the strange goings on on the Island. The day before, the body of young Mr Hambrough, which had been buried in St Catherine's Churchyard, in Ventnor, only a couple of weeks before, had been exhumed as part of a police inquest.

According to a newspaper report read out by one of the barflies, at the time of his death, Hambrough had been in Scotland, on the Ardlamont estate. In a tragic accident, he'd been out shooting with his guardian, stumbled somehow, or got caught up in a bush, and set off his gun with a fatal result. A terrible, terrible accident. Or was it? The matter of a newly arranged life insurance policy taken out against him hinted that perhaps it wasn't just an accident.

One of the drinkers suggested it was impossible that a man could hold a gun in such a way that if he stumbled, he'd be able to blow the back of his head off. At this point, Henry Card, dog under his arm, pint in his hand, disagreed, and said it was quite possible. Gun accidents happened all the time, and that's all that this was.

"You're talking nonsense", said the DFL, the down-from-Londoner. To which Card replied, "Bugger that, I'll show you", put his pint on the bar, his dog on the floor, and picked up his gun.

"Do you want to try? It's empty..." But the man declined, and so Henry Card himself cocked the gun, and with his right hand, put it behind his back, struggling to position it, just so, with the muzzle towards the back of his head.

"If you slung it like that", he said, "and stumbled, and it knocked the trigger..." He pulled the trigger. They all saw him pull the trigger.

There was nothing they could do. A man was immediately sent across to Lymington town on the ferry, to fetch the doctor, but there was nothing he could do to help the comatose man. A couple of hours later, Henry Card was dead.

At the inquest, the coroner returned a verdict of "Accidental Death".

So had Henry Card died in a similar way to the young Mr Cecil Dudley Hambrough, whose grave you can still see in St Catherine's churchyard today? Well, maybe, or maybe not, because that's a much longer tale, and one for another day.

The Last Island Duel

As with many of the historical stories I have "researched", rather than heard, this telling is an early snapshot of starting to forget the facts, and then find the story, based on historical news reports of the

time.

It's 1817. The war with France is over, and the paid off soldiers are looking for new opportunities. Regiments are being raised to go and fight in the South American Patriot war against the Spanish, and ships are being chartered to take scratch made regiments, volunteers, some may call them, mercenaries others, over to join the fight.

Moored off Cowes, the good ship Grace.

Several men come ashore, get pissed. Play billiards. "We're all in debt aren't we?" "What?" "In debt, that's why we're going isn't it? *For the money.*" "Take that back." "What?" "Take it back. How dare you say that? That I'm in debt?" "Oh come on, of course you are. We all are..." And then to the side "You reckon he's bankrupt then? He's certainly slow to get a round in!" "Take. It. Back." "What? Look, of course we're all in debt. To God if no-one else..." "You will take it back, or I will see you at first light." "What the f...".

A small boat goes over to the Grace, and shortly after returns. A box.

At first light, the men walk up to Northwood. One of the seconds marks the distance. "This is ridiculous." One of the duellists keeps his hand by his side, the gun uncocked. Falls at the first shot, the only shot, from the other man. They flee, leaving just the doctor in attendance.

The men abscond, are later apprehended in Portsmouth. Put on trial and found guilty of manslaughter.

But the story doesn't quite end there.

Not surprisingly, the duel has brought a certain amount of attention to the good ship Grace from which the duellists had come ashore. The Customs men go aboard to check the paperwork.

No roster, ship impounded. On further investigation, the owners have form (*but that's another tale altogether*). Some time later, the Captain comes ashore, on-board, the passengers and crew are tired of waiting. They take things into their own hands, and set sail.

And there the tale that does come to an end, a tale that I thought would be just a quick tale of a duel, but turned out to be a whole lot more. Because in historical tales in particular, one story often has the habit of turning into another.

John the Painter — A Telling

There is, or was, a pub called the Ship in Portsmouth, alongside the Hard. There are actually two old pubs called The Ship, more or less, down there to this day, so this story could well be about either of them, or both of them, or neither of them.

Sat in the corner, just round from the fire, you'd often see the figure of an old sailor: Old Tom, a clay pipe in his mouth, a stoppered glass bottle peaking out of his coat pocket. At one time, he made what little coin he'd need, selling fair winds to sailors bound for the East Indies, or the Americas, sailors fearful of not ever making it home again because they'd been becalmed. These were the days of sail, remember, so the sailors'd come and they'd purchase one of Tom's little stoppered bottles, and if the situation ever required it, they could pop the stopper out, and a fresh wind would blow, and they'd be on their way homeward again. But since Tom had caught the ghost, well, he didn't need to sell fair winds any more. Since he'd caught the ghost, he had all the pies he could eat and all the pints he could drink.

But before I tell you how that came about, I need to tell you about John the Painter. The son of an Edinburgh blacksmith, his father's death meant he received a scholarship to a local school, and an

apprenticeship with a local painter. But it was a far cry from the commission in the army he aspired to, so he made his way to London, where he partied and gambled away what little money he had. His short time as a highwayman paid quite well, but the career prospect of hanging from the gallows didn't appeal, so he tried America. Then came back, just as the American Revolutionary War began, with a handful of revolutionary tracts to read on the way home.

And now he was in Oxford, listening to the chat around him. The Navy's success was only partly due to the ships, and only partly due to the sailors. The *key* to its success was the dockyards. And if you take *those* out... John the Painter felt a plan coming together.

He made his way to Paris and pitched his idea to an American delegate there. They weren't totally convinced, but they didn't say no. Which he took as a yes, and so he set off to Canterbury, where a tinsmith made him a contraption of his own devising, rather clever, even if did say so himself, mechanical magic, even. A slow burn incendiary device. Or as the tinsmith called it, a tin can without a base and some holes in the top.

Back to Portsmouth, and as is the way of even the *best* laid plans, they never quite work out the way you want them to. It was November: night came early, and work stopped early. John the Painter hid one of his cans in the hemp store, then made his way to the rope store, a huge brick building, over 350 yards long, just imagine that, a fifth of a mile long. He tried to light a slow burn fuse, another invention of his own design, but it was damp. And it Just, Wouldn't, Light. And then, wouldn't you know it, when he tried to get out of the rope house, it had been locked up for the night.

He banged on door. Then he banged on the door and shouted. "'Scuse me.. Excuse me... Anyone there? ANYONE THERE?"

Eventually, a couple of men heard the banging, and let him out — "I'm sorry, I just wandered in, curious like, you know" - and they would remember seeing him, later, John the Painter, the Scottish chap, with the pale complexion and the strange fan tailed hat.

Back in his lodging room that night, he tried to perfect his slow burn fuse. Clouds of smoke everywhere. He could hear the landlady clattering up the stairs: "What the hell do you think you're doing? Trying to burn my house down?" And she threw him out first thing the next morning.

But now he was a man on a mission. Back into the dockyard, where he noticed a couple of ships in at the dock, laden with stores, packed with gunpowder. He smiled. Went into the hemp house to light the candle in the canister he'd left there the day before. But this time, his homemade matches wouldn't light. You know that feeling? Damp matches. Or the lighter that doesn't? So out of the dockyard he treks yet again, gets some new matches, and back again. Straight to the rope store. No messing this time.

As he makes his way out of town, he looks back towards Portsmouth, an orange glow on the horizon.

Marines and sailors from the dockyard, citizens of Portsea, had been quick to action, and only the rope store was lost, albeit all three hundred and fifty brick built yards of it. But was it arson, or just an accident?

A couple of men were arrested as they climbed out of one of the windows, but they'd been caught inside when the fire had started. A brief attempt was made to find, and question the man seen in the dockyard the day before, John the Painter, but there was no real evidence it was arson, so they let the matter drop there.

He tried again. Guards were set in Plymouth dockyard, but he had more success in Bristol, setting fire to several ships and warehouses there. But by now, the tin can device he had left in the hemp store in

Portsmouth had been found and identified for what it was. And a description of John the Painter had been released.

In one of those strange quirks of fate, he'd been arrested the day before. For petty stealing. In the jail, he was recognised from his description and identified as John the Painter.

Under questioning in London, he was convinced the evidence against him was purely circumstantial. The case wasn't strong enough to prosecute him for high treason, and he was sure he'd get off on the charge of arson. Which he might have done if he hadn't confided in another painter, a man who'd also done a stint in America, about what he had done. If only that man hadn't been a spy.

In March 1777, James Aitken — then, as now, better known as John the Painter — was hanged on the Hard, from the tallest gallows Britain had ever seen, over 60 feet high, made from the mizen mast of a ship in the dock. It is said that twenty thousand people watched him execution, saw his body cut down then hung in chains on Blockhouse beach, to be washed over by the tides each day. *(You can still see the iron cage in which his tarred body was hung in the small tower museum in Winchester to this day.)*

One newspaper report suggests that some time later — and gibbeted bodies could be on display for *years* — the head was stolen and hidden in the chimney of a Gosport pub. But in the *story* I was told, the head was taken on tour, and shown around the various pubs of Gosport and Portsmouth for a penny a look.

Including at the Ship inn, down on the Hard, where Old Tom used to sit just in the back there, round the corner, by the fireside. Clay pipe in his mouth, a stoppered bottle in his pocket. So the head turned up there, and it brought the punters in. Not that the Ship necessarily needed to put on gigs like that, because the pub also had a good trade in letting out rooms by the hour.

But then, one night, the head went missing.

And the rooms that were previously let by the hour were now abandoned after barely a minute or two thanks to the arrival of a rather unwelcoming ghost.

The local priest was called, but it was beyond his pay grade. The Bishop was called, but he knew the reputation of the place. Then someone had the bright idea of asking Old Tom. He was well versed in capturing the wind, he knew the ways of the world, perhaps he could help.

"Well maybe I can, and maybe I can't," he said, "but I can have a damn good try. But I'll want paying, mind, in beer and pies, for as long as it keeps away. I'll just need couple or three o' things. An empty bottle, I have. A full bottle, I need. And an empty glass." And when the landlord looked at him, not sure about what he meant, Tom pointed to the shelf behind the bar. "That bottle of rum should do it."

Old Tom went up the stairs, taking a cork out of the empty bottle in his pocket as he did so.

Went into the room that was usually let for an hour, and closed the door behind him. And waited. Poured himself a tot of rum, and then another, and then a third. And as he sat there, he felt the room get cold, felt something there beside him, saw a ghostly figure appear in front of him. And laughed — "you cabin boys up to your tricks again? Be gone with you." And the ghost replied, "Oh no, Tom Blue, be gone with YOU." And Old Tom just sat there and poured himself another drink. He'd been to the Indies, and back; he'd been to the Americas; and he'd seen a thing or two. And this was nothing to be afraid of. "So how did you get in then?" and he looked around the room. "Through the keyhole, I suppose? What nonsense. If you could get in through the keyhole, you should be able to get yourself into this bottle too..." and he placed the empty bottle from his pocket in the centre of the table. The ghost started to fade, to turn to a mist, and then, *thwupppp*, and into the bottle. Old Tom, quick as flash: stopper in the bottle. Finished the rum. Made his way back down to the bar, a stoppered bottle in his pocket, an empty one, and an empty glass, in his hands.

The landlord offered on of his regular customers the room for an hour, and more, if he needed it, free of charge. When he still hadn't come down even after a couple of hours, the landlord knew the ghost had gone. Poured old Tom a pint. Asked him what pie he'd like.

For as long as that ghost stayed away, Tom continued to be paid in pints and pies, no longer needing to make coin selling fair winds to the sailors. But it wasn't long before either the pints or the pies got him, and he went to meet his maker. As to what happened to that last stoppered bottle, the story doesn't say. But it does tell that in the months and years after his death, the ghost of Old Tom could still be seen, clay china pipe in his mouth and a stoppered bottle in his pocket, sitting in the corner, just round from the fire. And every so often he'd take the bottle out of his pocket, hold it up to the light, and smile.

Mistakes, Attempted Escapes, and a Spectacle on Southsea Common — The Tale of David Tyrie

It's late August, around about the same weekend the Victorious Festival takes place each year today, and seventy or eighty thousand people congregate on Southsea common for a weekend of festival frolicking and fun by the seaside.

Back then, in 1782, almost 250 years ago, it is said that a *hundred* thousand were gathered there, surrounding a small platform especially erected for the event. A festival of a different sort.

A hundred thousand people. The same as a sell out Victorious Festival at full capacity.

Out in the Solent, at Spithead, a fleet is assembled. A spectacular view from Portsmouth, and a spectacular view from Ryde, too. Ships would only go into port if they were going in for repairs. The fleet was preparing a trip down to Gibraltar as part of a relief operation. They'd also be escorting ships of the East India company on the first part of their journey.

A few days before, the Royal George, pride of Lord Howe's fleet, 100 guns on board, was taking on board supplies. A full complement of crew on board each ship, and the rest: friends, and families and over familiar females. As they look towards Southsea Common, they hear a huge cheer go up. Twenty minutes later, an "oooh", and an "errrghh..." and a "oahhhh"...

A bit later again, there's some activity on the beach, a crowd surge perhaps, a bit like a pitch invasion or surge around a Formula One podium today. And then, a huddle of people on board ship as something very special is shown around.

So what just happened?

Back in those days, if you were a regular reader of the Hampshire Chronicle, you'd be well versed in reading about ship movements, the number of guns they had, where they'd supposedly been and where they were supposedly going, which Captains were on board, maybe even how many men. Common knowledge. But the sort of knowledge, in another form, that could also get you in trouble. A lot of trouble.

Six months before, David Tyrie, or Tie-ree, cocked up. A Scot, a native of Edinburgh, apprenticed in Leith, someone who could have made it as a successful businessman in London, if he hadn't got involved in a rather complicated fraud, Tyrie was now in the information business. Using spotters at the Naval Docks, and his own access to the Navy Office, where he'd previously worked, he was selling information about the state of the Navy to the French.

And now he was in Portsmouth. And everything was going wrong. The skipper he'd used before for taking messages over to France under cover of being a smuggler was unavailable, so he'd had to take on another Captain. To run the messages, a young man he'd know and brought down from Edinburgh

who'd also recorded Naval movements for him. But as Tyrie was putting the latest information pack together, "Oh f-k....". That sinking feeling, in the pit of your stomach. "Oh crap"... For some time, Tyrie had been "borrowing" official lists from the Navy Office, copying them in his own hand, returning the original so no-one would know. "S-t". It was original... he must have put the *copy*, the copy *in his own handwriting*, handwriting which *people in his previous office would know* to be his. "Crap, crap, crap."

It was too late now... he put the signals together, for getting into the harbour at the other side, sealed the papers for the French, and went to see his man.

Who wasn't overly comfortable with what he was being asked to do. Tyrie had told him when he first recruited him he was collating information for the Navy. That it would be officially checked by them before it was "passed on". But the young man hadn't been convinced, and had.. not quite made up the numbers and the names of the ships, but.. well, he massaged them a bit. If there were being checked anyway, they'd be corrected.

But now there was talk of sailing over to France, and a packer of signals —what "signals"? Naval signals? This wasn't what he'd signed up for. So he went to take advice. Was asked where he'd got the papers. "We need to show these to someone."

Meanwhile, Tyrie, kicking himself about his mistake in putting his handwritten copied papers back, not the original, knew there could be trouble. "What am I gonna do? They're going to know? They're going to come after me?" He'd kept copies of the copies, of course he had, proof of information sent, but now they could be a liability?" "Well, I could take them, up to London, give them to someone there, someone no-one suspect", and so it was, his heading up to town on the very next coach. Took the papers to an old schoolmistress friend of hers: "can you take care of these for me, for my husband? But don't let anyone see them? Please, he's in terrible trouble, and, please, can you do that?" The woman said yes, but she was suspicious. Looked at the papers. Took them to a friend. "Where did you get these? These are treasonous? We must take them to someone..."

In the Navy Office, a clerk comes across a document. The mice have been very active lately, papers going missing for a day or two and then magically reappearing. This was one such document. But it wasn't the original. It was a copy. And that handwriting was familiar.

A watch was placed on the school mistress's house. When Tyrie's wife reappeared a few days later, she was picked up.

A few days later, her husband was arrested.

They were held for questioning in London. Mrs Tyrie, just a messenger, was released, while Tyrie was sent to Newgate.

At that time, people went in and out of the Bridewell all the time. Prisons then were a form of enforced budget hotel accommodation, with everything sold as an add on. Visitors were frequent, bringing food and other niceties into the jail. This also gave an opportunity for networking. I'm not sure how it happened, but happen it did, and one of the visitors, a forger by trade, got friendly with Tyrie and offered to help him escape. The plan was this: Tyrie had made friends with the guards, who'd told him he was to be moved to Winchester for trial later that week. When he went, it would be early, 5 in the morning. Tyrie put his plan to paper, in a letter he gave to the forger. "We need a man on the outside, someone who can recognise me, they need to come in an visit, name to face and all that. If we go in a car, it'll be from the door; if we're on the coach, it'll be the inn. They need to be around Old Bailey and Newgate Street each morning, from about three till half six, to see if I come out. Or the Hyde Park Turnpike, we'd have to go through there too." (These were horse drawn vehicles, remember. This was the 1780s after all.) "If you get three or four men, dressed as waggoners, good

horses, handkerchiefs over their faces, that should do it; everyone'll reckon them as smugglers. And tell them I'm a smuggler, they're rescuing a smuggler. About the 23rd mile stone, on Bagshot Heath, you could do it there. Unless you know somewhere better. We should be there about eleven if we're on the coach, maybe half nine in if we're in the car. And I'll need a fast horse or car to get away. And snuff. Lots of snuff. I know it sounds strange, but we can throw it in the guard's eyes. And a punch, for knocking the chains off my legs. I may get a nod the night before. If so, I could probably get a message out, though not too far away. A mile or so maybe? But not to your house. That would be careless."

But this was perhaps a bit too much for the forger; no rescue attempt was actually made. And so it was, that Tyrie was taken to Winchester on a charge of High Treason.

He made a motion to put off the trial: "My Lord, four of my witnesses aren't ready; a female witness, who is in Tothill-fields bridewell; two sailors, they're abroad; and another man, who lives in Ostend." "What are you talking about, not ready? You've had months to prepare: motion denied."

The case was swift. On being found guilty, he was asked, in the usual way, why sentence of death should not be passed. His response? "There's nothing I can say; I'm convicted because I'm poor, because I hadn't the means to bring my witnesses; I despise all that has been done to me."

The judge donned his black cap and the most dreadful of sentences was passed.

But despite the grim fate awaiting him, Tyrie wasn't overly concerned. He was already working on another plan. For the previous week or two, he'd been busy, along with other prisoners in the cell. The walls had recently been whitewashed, but if you knew just where to look... there, just there... an irregular shaped line of cement; chip it out, ease out the plank, not plaster, and: a possible way out. At first glance it looked like brickwork, but the bricks were loose and could be easily taken out; and there were tools hidden in the gap there, too: a hammer; some chisels; a hand saw.

The execution date may have been approaching, but they must nearly be through the wall by now. It really couldn't be much further. "So how thick are the walls, then?" Tyrie had asked one of the jailers. Big mistake. "Three feet? Why? Are you thinking of breaking out through it?" "No, not at all, not at all," said Tyrie, "I was just... *curious*. But it does seem rather excessive."

But the jailer's curiosity had been piqued; he looked round the cell, tapped the wall every so often, here, there, there, here, and: tapped on wood, not stone; saw the jagged of what look like fresh cement. Broke through the panel, and: "Hah, so, not trying to escape then?"

A large crowd had gathered outside the jail by four that the morning, some of the keenest perhaps getting there the night before, sleeping out to guarantee a good view. By five, Tyrie was put into a coach, pulled by six horses, and set off for Portsmouth. "I was supposed to have been rescued, you know, the Smugglers offered to do it, it's just they just wanted too much, way more than I could raise."

Like John the Painter before him, warning of how easy it would be to attack the Naval dock at Plymouth, Tyrie also had a message for the authorities: there was someone else out there, someone still giving information to the French.

Unlike John the Painter, there wouldn't be a flurry of official confessions, no execution day merch. Tyrie made it clear he had nothing to say, no final confession exclusives.

The crowd already gathered at Southsea Common was immense. A hundred thousand people, it's said. And out in the Solent, at Spithead, it was busier than normal there, too, as the expeditionary fleet took on stores, and crowds gathered on deck to look out at the spectacle on the common.

Tyrie was hanged for exactly twenty-two minutes; still not quite dead, he was lowered on to the stage; his privities cut off (ooohhh...), his bowels cut out (errrghh...), and his heart taken out (oahhhh). “Behold the heart of a traitor” and into a fire. Then his head was cut off, and his body quartered, and placed into a coffin, which was then buried under the pebbles on the beach. It is said, that as soon as the officers retired, sailors dug up the coffin, took out the body, and cut it in a thousand pieces, each one carrying away a piece of Tyrie’s body to show to their messmates on board.

Whether any of the men on board the Royal George had acquired any of the body parts of the traitor Tyrie as some of macabre luck charm, I don’t know. But I do know that three days after the execution, stores were still being loaded on board her.

During her last voyage, she’d been taking on more water than usual, so a running repair was also required. It was something and nothing, a small pipe which let water into the hold for cleaning the ship. But it needed replacing. It was usually about three feet below the surface of the water, a faff to get to, so they’d have to heel the ship — lean her over to the other side, to raise the pipe out of the water.

The guns on the port side of the ship were run out of the port-holes as far as they would go; those from the starboard side were drawn in to the middle of the ship. She heeled over to one side, just enough to provide access to the pipe that needed replacing. Each wave brought some water into through the port holes at the lower side, but not enough to be of concern. The men had great fun chasing all the mice displaced in the lower part of the boat by this sudden influx of water.

Stores were still being brought on board, not least the rum, so it made sense to do that on the lower side — less distance to heave up the barrels. Several men went over to that side of the ship to help haul in the rum. The ship leant a tiny bit more. The barrels were brought on board. And the ship leaned a little more. The ship’s carpenter sought out the officers in charge, told them “she’s heeling too much.” The first ignored him, the second gave him a bollocking: “if you think you can manage the ship better than I can, you’d better take the command”. A slight breeze sprang up. The cannon-balls started sliding; the *cannons* started sliding. And it just a moment more. The Royal George tipped onto her side, and went down.

The watch on deck was 200 men or so. There were hundreds more, six, seven, eight hundred maybe, below deck; men, women — wives, and not — children, merchants, traders, and more. The men on board deck could climb up the rigging — the ship was only in shallow water, the top of the masts were visible above the waterline men, but the rest were lost. Two hundred men or so were saved, who knows how many more were lost.

Many of the bodies were washed ashore at Ryde. But also, one very unusual survivor, at least. On board the ship, kept on the main deck, was a certain amount of livestock — fresh milk and meat for the voyage, presumably. Amongst which were two sheep, who managed to make it off the ship and swam to Ryde. This is surprising enough, perhaps, but more so was that a young child, aged between two and three years old, whose parents had been on the ship and were lost in the disaster, also came ashore, one arm around the neck of each of the sheep. It is said that a Naval Officer who was present said he would adopt the child.

Today, the Royal George Memorial Gardens in Ryde, just off the roundabout by the Castle Hotel, serves as a reminder of the tragic affair.

There was no way the ship could be raised at the time, even though she was in shallow water. The size of her, the water inside her, the water above, was just too much. As it was, the Royal George remained a hazard for many years, only to be blasted to smithereens in 1840s.

As for the remains of David Tyrie, the stories don't say what happened to any of his remains that remained on the beach, don't tell whether the hands of that hanged and quartered man were used to make particularly effective hands of glory — do you know about the hand of glory? That's maybe a tale for another day — though did hear one tale that some of the finger bones ended up as bottle stoppers. But we do know what happened to the head: the keeper of Gosport Bridewell got hold of it. And put it on show for a shilling a go.

There is, in the newspaper archives, the report of a sailor, lately arrived from the West-Indies, took his girlfriend to see it — well, you would, wouldn't you? — took her for a nice glass of wine, took her to the Bridewell, had a quiet word with the gaoler — “can we see the head?” The gaoler disappeared for a few minutes, returned with what looked like a tray something on it, covered with a cloth. Carefully, lifted the cloth off.... Immediately, the young woman fainted, was taken home, and put to bed. She never rose again. The sailor, distraught at what he had done, made several attempts on his own life.

And that is the tale of the sinking of the Royal George, and a few days before it, of the execution of David Tyrie.

The Spithead Mutiny — A Telling (*Work in Progress*)

It's 1797. Between Ryde and Portsmouth, in the anchorage known as Spithead, the new Admiral of the Channel Fleet, Lord Bridport, reviews sixteen ships of the line, and the rest, as they assemble there, making ready to go out on patrol against the French.

These weren't the happiest of times for the sailors. Many of them would've been taken by the press gangs, others given the unsavoury “choice” of the Navy or the debtor's prison.

The rations would rarely pass muster, the provisions short-served: 12 ounces to the pound, not sixteen; the same short measures of rum. The purser had the rest, his pay being determined by how much he could save. Salt beef would be months, if not years, old, so hard you could polish it, so foul tasting you'd tie it to a line and through it in the sea to try to wash the worst of it out; and the ship's biscuits? Hard as stone, though the weevils didn't care.

The laws that regulated life on board ship — the *Articles of War*, as they were known — were read out regularly, reminding the men of what was expected of them, of the punishments for various offences. *Compulsory training*, you might call it. Mutiny was a big no-no, but the men *were* allowed to raise concerns with their Captain, or the Commander-in-Chief. Not that it ever did much good.

As for the pay? Well, that hadn't changed since the time of Charles II, a hundred or more so years ago. Inflation hadn't really existed then, but prices what with the war, and the new fangled machines and factories everywhere, prices had just kept on going up, and not going back down, like they'd always used to.

So amidst the fleet of ships of war, small boats started to ferry about round-robin letters of discontent, letters calling for increased pay, better provisions — and a fairer share of them — *and* a better share of any prize money. Because at that time, navy ships could operate in pirate mode, and take what prizes they could from boarded ships. The officers had always got the biggest share of course. But now the men wanted a big part of it. The letters were all the same, and all unsigned, but dated by the same hand. They were then gathered together and sent to the fleet's much loved previous admiral (*Lord Howe*) who'd been invalided out a short time previously with a rather painful bout of gout. Rations for the officers obviously weren't so bad as they were for the men.

When he saw the letters, he immediately discounted them, thinking they were the work of a single man, a trouble maker. But then, a little pang of concern, maybe? and he had one of his old men make

enquiries.

“All’s well”, came back the reply.

But all was not well.

When the fleet sailed to keep tabs on the French, the men fully expected that their old Admiral would have sorted things out by the time they returned.

How naive they were....

Their mood got worse.

Dissatisfaction grew, particularly on board the old admiral’s flagship, the Charlotte, a ship that had a reputation for its rather lax and turbulent discipline.

The small boats started criss-crossing again, out from the Charlotte, and back again. A plan was made.

With Easter fast approaching, the men spent Maundy Thursday and Good Friday putting petitions together, petitions that would *this time* go straight to the Admiralty. On Easter Monday, they would take action, hoist a flag, and refuse to sail the next time they were told to weigh anchor.

Sensing that all wasn’t well, the new admiral tried to get ahead of the game and ordered one of his squadrons round to St. Helens on Easter Sunday, in preparation of then sailing out into the Channel.

Even though the petitions weren’t ready yet, the men responded immediately. And the mutiny began.

But not a violent or a riotous mutiny.

The officers were still to be respected, discipline would be maintained, but the ships wouldn’t sail when ordered to (at least, not unless the French came calling: the men were still loyal to Britain, and to the King).

Ropes over the yard arms as a sign that the men were in charge. Hangings were typically from the yard arm, so I’m pretty sure that some of the officers might have thought the ropes were intended for them. As it was, they doubled up to show that breaches of discipline would not be tolerated by the rest of the men.

There were no mobile phones in those days of course, so if a meeting had to be called, a red flag was flown on the Charlotte, a sign that the delegates from the other ships should make their way over, *pronto*.

The new admiral tried to be reasonable, and told his Captains to get a list of grievances, which were all much the same: better pay, a fairer share of provisions, fairer prize money and pensions, improved shore leave, and better treatment from the officers.

The next day, Easter Monday, the men took an oath to the cause: if they were unanimous, united, it would be impossible to punish them all. They’d tried petitioning their old admiral, which had got them nowhere; so now they’d try the Admiralty, direct, in combination.

The patients at Haslar, the naval hospital that looks out towards Spithead from the mouth of Portsmouth harbour, could hear cheers from on board the ships of the fleet. When news of the mutiny reached them, they raised their voices in three cheers too, hanging banners made of handkerchiefs tied together and waving flags from their windows in support.

That afternoon, a delegation set out from the Admiralty in London, and got to the Fountain Inn in Portsmouth — it’s no longer there — by noon the following day.

At their meeting, they agreed to slightly improved wages and better pensions.

But the men wanted more... Fairer provisions, better treatment and so on. And a pardon: every man should receive a pardon for the mutiny.

Now, at this point, the Board grew suspicious: for every concession, would the men ask for more. So they told admiral to tell the men: take it or leave it, and you can have your pardon. Or suffer the full consequences of your actions.

At the same time, the Admiralty believed in divide and conquer. If the less mutinous ships could be sailed round to St. Helens, the mutiny could be more easily brought to an end.

The admiral advised against it, told the Admiralty folk the only real solution was to make the additional concessions, and even then it would require a unanimous decision from the committee that met on the Charlotte. The red flag went up, and the little boats brought the delegates from the other ships to the Charlotte. But then, they had to wait for the delegates from the Charlotte and the Admiral's flagship, the Royal George, who were still ashore.

On board *his* ship, one of Rear Admirals, Gardner was his name, was tired of waiting; he took a boat over to the Charlotte.

Meanwhile, the men had made decision to accept the terms, as long as the pardon was a King's Pardon, with a the trapping the Royal Seal and what have you. Gardner was livid, and grabbed one of the delegates; "I'll have you all hanged, each and every one of you, and one in five of every seamen in the fleet."

Now as you can imagine, this didn't go down well. But somehow, and I don't know quite how, Gardner's men managed to get him off the ship alive...

Gardner had really messed things up. The men were now suspicious about the Admiralty offer and started to prepare the guns and set a watch. The Admiral's flag had still been flying on his flagship up to this point — the men were still loyal, just making a point — but rather than see the Admiral's flag sullied, his officers took the flag down. But the men were still the Admiral's men, and didn't want to lose his support, so they wrote to him as the "father of the fleet", asking him not to abandon them, and to reassume his command.

Meanwhile, a further demand had been made: the men didn't want just the Royal Pardon, even with all it's fancy stamps and seals, they also wanted Parliament to sign off the concessions the Admiralty had supposedly agree to.

The Admiralty men went back to London, and the Prime Minister went to see the King.

A Royal proclamation was signed, and sealed, and a hundred copies printed off. Then it was sent, post haste, to Portsmouth.

On board the Charlotte, the men were still suspicious. Their copy looked like a Royal Pardon, but was it? They demanded to see the original, which then had to be brought over from the Royal George.

Satisfied by the original, the ropes over the yard arms were taken down, and the week long Spithead mutiny was over.

Or at least, the *first* Spithead mutiny was over.

Several ships were sent round to St. Helens, and the whole fleet prepared to set sail. But the wind conditions weren't quite right — the wind was too strong from the East — so it waited.

The provisions had started to improve — that much, at least, was that something that could be done. But the Admiralty felt they had to prove they were back in charge, so they issued new orders: the

regular reading of the rules on-board, the Articles of War, would be enforced; *and* there would be regular musters of the ships' crew; *and* there would be increased supervision over shore leave.

The mutterings started again.

And not just about the Admiralty; about Parliament too. Remember, the men had added Parliamentary approval of the Admiralty's concessions to their demands, but in the weekend newspapers were reports that no decisions had been made in the House of Commons, and no Parliamentary papers were being sent to the Lords.

The ropes were thrown back over the yard arms, the red flags were flying again, and from each of the ships a little boat was crossing over to the Charlotte. Just a couple of weeks after the end of the *first* mutiny, the *second* Spithead mutiny had begun.

On board the London, another Rear Admiral, Colpoys this time, had seen the boats starting to dart between the Charlotte and the other ships. He rightly suspected something was going on. He consulted with his officers, gave orders to the marines: "stop any of those delegates coming on board this ship," then told his men he'd stand by them, but they should go below decks.

The men went below deck, as the marines stayed on board deck.

The had a drink...

And the men started to get a little bit rowdy...

They tried to come up on deck, but the marines pushed them back, aimed their guns at the hatches. And then the order came: "fire". A short gun battle ensued, men on both sides were wounded. Three of the seamen later died. The coroner's verdict would later be *justifiable homicide*.

Across the fleet, the seamen started to take control. Officers were sent ashore, and several ships sailed round to St. Helens.

Some of the more credulous and revolutionary men started to gossip that the fleet would sail to Brest, to join with the French. But the great majority of the men were still loyal to the flag, loyal *to the King*. Even if they were suspicious of the Admiralty. And of Parliament.

It was now the Monday after the Friday before. The papers formally costing the Admiralty's concessions *had* been prepared for Parliament the week before, it was just that the Commons wasn't sitting on the Friday, so there'd be no papers to pass to the Lords that day. Which was what the newspapers had reported. Sort of.

But the Commons were sitting so a Bill could be tabled. It completed all the necessary stages the following day, including Royal Assent, and was passed into law.

This time, 30 copies of the Act were hastily printed and given to the Admiral. The beloved old Admiral, the one who'd not picked up on the original letters of complaint while he was laid up with gout, also headed down to Portsmouth, to share the news on board his old flagship, the Charlotte, and the new admiral's flagship, the Royal George.

But still the seamen added to their demands.

This time, they wanted the worst of the officers, officers who had already been sent ashore, not to be allowed back on-board. "We don't need them to be court-martialled," they said, "they're just not welcome back on board."

Perhaps surprisingly, their conditions were agreed to. The Admiralty couldn't risk losing control of the Channel fleet for a third time. The red flags came down, the ropes were removed from the yard arms, and the little boats stopped their criss-crossing to and from the Princess Charlotte.

A celebration was organised, including a procession through Portsmouth, the old Admiral leading the way. The new Admiral, who had done so much to argue the case for his men, may well have felt aggrieved. And not least because a fair wind was now blowing, and the sailing of the fleet had to be delayed for the procession.

But even as the celebrations continued, four men from the Nore fleet, anchored at the opening of the Thames Estuary, had arrived in Portsmouth. They'd started their own mutiny three days before, and had come to co-ordinate with the Portsmouth mutineers. They would return to continue their mutiny without the support of the Spithead fleet, a mutiny that would not end so happily, although that is another story, for another day.

As it was, for new the Admiral's fleet, Lord Bridport's fleet, it would set sail the following day. And if you had been at Ryde looking out into the Solent, sixteen ships of their line making their way out in to the Channel.

And that is the end of the tale.